the lack of a dynamic and inclusive leader. State president Jagdish Thakor is known as a good organiser, but lacks wide acceptability. The working president Hardik Patel—the face of the Patidar reservation agitation—seems to have lost his appeal after joining the Congress in 2017. "One can be a hero for only one cause. People won't accept you as a hero for every single cause," says a senior Congress leader.

The party hopes to do better in Saurashtra and south Gujarat. Like the BJP, the Congress, too, is trying to rope in Naresh Patel. As chairman of the Shri Khodaldham Trust, the biggest organisation of Leuva Patels, he has much influence over the community in 30-35 assembly constituencies. The trust manages the temple of Goddess Khodiyar, the community's patron deity, in Rajkot. As the Congress has been unable to attract upper-caste Hindus since 1990, Naresh Patel would be a prize catch. However, a section in the party believes his entry would alienate the OBCs as they don't get along with the Patidars. They are also sceptical on whether Hardik, a Kadva Patel, will accept Naresh.

## AAP MAKES INROADS

AAP, which has set its sights on Gujarat after its Punjab victory, cashed in on a chance to expose the chinks in the BJP-ruled state's education system. It all started with the national BJP social media team tweeting a caricature of AAP convenor and Delhi chief minister Arvind Kejriwal, criticising him for his handling of protests by schoolteachers in the national capital. On April 6, Gujarat education minister Jitu Vaghani asked those who do not like the schools in the state to go to whichever state or country they like. Delhi education minister Manish Sisodia retaliated the next day, saying the BJP has failed to improve the education system in Gujarat after 27 years of ruling the state. "People need not leave Gujarat. They will bring AAP to power and a glorious education system like in Delhi will be provided to them," he tweeted.

The BJP had chosen the wrong time to take on AAP over school education. After all, around 600 government schools—each of which had less than 20 students on its rolls—have been shut down in the past year in Gujarat, especially in tribal areas. The state has also seen protests by parents against high school fees. Clearly, Vaghani had been caught on the wrong foot and his party's top leaders eventually asked him to refrain from making unnecessary statements on education. But then the damage had been done by then.

As for AAP, its rise seems to have enlivened Gujarat's political landscape. The party completed its statewide 'Tiranga Yatra' in the first week of April. It organised rallies in each of the 182 assembly constituencies. AAP's Gujarat president Gopal Italia claims his party has at least 100 active workers in each constituency. Next in line is 'Jan Samvad', the party's mass contact campaign beginning on April 15, in which local leaders will interact with people to understand their problems.

**AAP'S RISE MAY HAVE ENLIVENED GUJARAT'S POLITICAL ATMOSPHERE, BUT IT HAS NOBODY TO SWING VOTES OF ANY CASTE GROUP**

At a roadside tea stall in Ahmedabad, Italia says, "The common people of Gujarat have started identifying with AAP." Clad in blue jeans and white shirt, the 32-year-old law graduate and Surat resident used his stopover at the stall (even though he arrived in a Land Cruiser) to say, "I am truly an *aam aadmi* (common man). I can sit anywhere and interact with people." According to Italia, AAP's outreach will focus on education and health. Alleging that people are fed up with the "arrogance" of BJP leaders, he says, "No one listens to their grievances. Anyone can build schools, but this government's mindset is dangerous. They are corrupting people's minds."

While AAP may have some of the youngest leaders in the state, none of them is a widely popular face. And it has nobody who can swing the votes of any caste group. However, Italia, a Leuva Patel, insists that Patidars, especially the youngsters among them, are not thinking along caste lines. "They will support anyone who has a vision for society irrespective of caste," he says. However, allegations that Italia has made statements mocking Hindu gods may damage the party's chances.

Meanwhile, AAP has started a publicity blitz on local TV channels, with Punjab CM Bhagwant Mann appearing every half an hour claiming his government has ended corruption in a week. Taking a leaf from Punjab, AAP has roped in its master strategist Sandeep Pathak, a Rajya Sabha member and former IIT-Delhi professor, to chalk out a plan for Gujarat. Pathak toured Ahmedabad for two days and announced on April 4 that AAP's internal survey shows it could win 58 seats in the next election. "People of rural Gujarat are voting for us. The lower and middle class in urban areas too want a change and will vote for us," he told reporters.

A source in the party, however, dismissed the report as exaggerated. "It is a tactic to boost our workers' morale. As of now, our biggest achievement is our presence in all 182 constituencies," the source says. Political observer Kashikar points out that even though AAP has a known face in former journalist Isudan Gadhvi, the party needs to strengthen its grassroots-level organisation. "Without it, they can't go beyond municipality elections," he says. AAP had failed to open its account in the 2017 election. This time, it hopes to do much better. ■